



◀ Custer's last stand

The Battle of Little Bighorn was fought between Plains Indians and US troops in June 1876. This artwork celebrates the Native victory and the death of US General Custer. Women (right) prepare a ceremony for the returning warriors.

Worse were the female outlaws. Bandit queen Belle Starr married a string of outlaw men, acting as their partner in crime to steal horses, cattle, and cash.

War for the Plains

In 1830, President Jackson signed the Indian Removal Act, calling for the relocation of the Cherokee, Choctaw, Creek, Chickasaw, and Seminole Indians to land west of the Mississippi River. These forced relocations from Southeastern states became known as the "Trail of Tears" because the tribes had to march in bad weather, and were also subject to disease and starvation. Cherokee woman Chin Deenawash, the only member of her family to survive relocation,

even had to dig a trail-side grave for her youngest child with only a broken knife case. As Americans began to settle land farther

beyond the Mississippi, the tribes of the Plains—notably the Lakota Sioux and their allies—fought back. From the 1850s until the bloody massacre of the Lakota at Wounded Knee in 1890, warfare broke out regularly. Native women both fought in the skirmishes and suffered as casualties of attacks. The Plains people were ultimately

defeated and forced onto reservations—small parcels of land—on which they were pressured to embrace American culture.

90
Shoshone women
were killed by US
troops in the Bear
River Massacre
in January 1863.

BIOGRAPHY

BUFFALO CALF ROAD WOMAN

Probably born in the 1850s, Buffalo Calf Road Woman was part of the Northern Cheyenne nation and lived on the northern plains. As the only Cheyenne woman fighting in the Battle of the Rosebud in June 1876, she gained some renown for riding her horse directly into the fray to rescue her brother. The Cheyenne referred to the conflict as the "Battle Where the Girl Saved her Brother," and she was granted the name "Brave Woman" by Cheyenne chief Box Elder for her actions. She went on to fight alongside her husband in the Battle of Little Bighorn. Buffalo Calf Road Woman died in 1879.